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[GS PAPER II – INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS • GS PAPER III – INTERNAL SECURITY] | **Publication Date: 27/09/2026**

THE ARCTIC RACE



The article explores the growing strategic importance of Greenland in the Arctic and the United States' expanding interest in the region. It examines the geopolitical, security, economic and resource dimensions shaping the evolving US–Greenland relationship.

THE ARCTIC RACE

US – Greenland deal

Syllabus areas:

GS Paper II – International Relations

GS Paper III – Internal Security

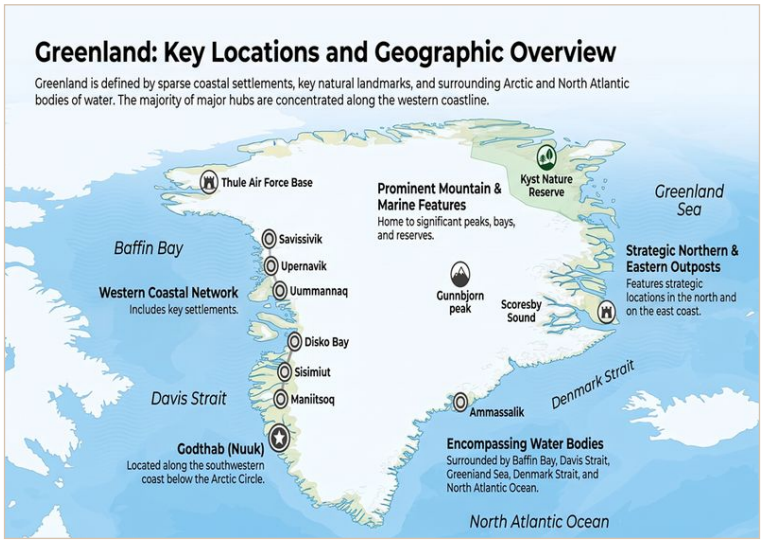
"Essentially, it's a large real estate deal. A lot of things can be done,"
U.S. President Donald Trump said in **August 2019**, during his first term, when asked whether the U.S. would be interested in acquiring Greenland.

After he returned to office in **January 2025**, Mr. Trump repeated his threat.

"We need Greenland for national security purposes," he said in January 2025.

"You look outside. You have Chinese ships all over the place. You have Russian ships all over the place. We're not letting that happen."

Greenland, a **Danish territory** located between the **Arctic Ocean** and the **North Atlantic Ocean,** was home to at least **30 American military bases and installations** during the Second World War. The island's strategic profile grew in recent years after **Russia and China stepped up their activities in the Arctic region,** partly because of ice melting which opened up previously impassable regions. Mr. Trump's threats to take over the island in **Denmark, a founding member of NATO,** and America's other European allies. The crisis further strained the transatlantic ties. But on **September 22,** on the sidelines of the **UN General Assembly,** leaders of the **U.S., Denmark and Greenland** signed a new security agreement, which, according to Mr. Trump, would allow the U.S. "to do what is necessary in Greenland".





The **1951 U.S.-Denmark security agreement** provides Washington **broad rights to build military bases** in the ice-covered island.

Most American bases on the island were shut down over the years, particularly after the Cold War. Now the U.S. stations **some 150 troops** at its **Pituffik Space Base in Greenland.**

U.S. officials wanted to **increase this military presence** which they argued was important to **monitor and defend the northern approaches of North America and the North Atlantic** at a time when the **race to control the Arctic is heating up.**

Russia has **extensive Arctic territory** and **military infrastructure.**

Greenland also possesses **significant mineral resources,** including **rare earths,** a segment which is currently **dominated by China.**

U.S. officials have raised concerns about potential **Chinese investments in Greenland.**

So Washington wants to **compete with Russia in the Arctic** and **build new military infrastructure** to monitor movement in the frozen waters and **prevent Chinese influence** in the region, besides making sure that America has **access to the island's mineral resources.**

Denmark, which has already blocked Chinese investments in Greenland, had said it would **allow Washington to expand its military presence** on the island, but insisted that **Danish sovereignty and Greenland's self-governing rights** be respected. The latest security agreement with the U.S. sought to address both America's demands and Danish concerns.

According to the agreement, even if Greenland, which has a **population of around 50,000, becomes independent,** it would respect the deal with the U.S. and stay within NATO. In other words, this deal provides the U.S. **indefinite access** to the island's military facilities.

The deal, which reaffirms **"the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Kingdom of Denmark"** and recognises the **"self determination of the people of Greenland",** also stipulates that **no hostile power (non-NATO countries)** can establish military facilities on the island or invest in its **sensitive areas** (mainly rare earths).

The U.S. will be allowed to establish **additional defence facilities** in **Narsarsuaq** in the south, where it had an airfield during the Second World War, and in **Mestersvig** in the east. The Mestersvig facility would allow the U.S. to **monitor the waters between the island and the Scandinavian region.**

Greenland would also be part of the **U.S. Golden Dome anti-missile shield,** and Danish authorities have pledged to work together with Washington to **counter espionage in Greenland,** a reference to alleged **Chinese activities** in the region.

On paper, Greenland would remain a **self-governing territory of Denmark.** But in practice, the **U.S. would have indefinite rights to build military facilities** on the island and **a say in its economic policies and resource extraction.** Mr. Trump may not have secured ownership of the world's largest island, but appears to have secured almost everything else.